

Make your answers as specific as possible. For the first question, explicit statements like “I’m trying to install the latest version of Python on my new Windows laptop” are detailed enough for others in the Python community to help you. Statements like “I’m trying to install Python” don’t provide enough information for others to offer much help.

Your answer to the second question should provide enough detail so you won’t be advised to repeat what you’ve already tried: “I went to <https://python.org/downloads> and clicked the Download button for my system. Then I ran the installer” is more helpful than “I went to the Python website and downloaded something.”

For the third question, it’s helpful to know the exact error messages you received, so you can use them to search online for a solution or provide them when asking for help.

Sometimes, just answering these three questions before you ask for help from others allows you to see something you’re missing, and helps get you unstuck without having to go any further. Programmers even have a name for this: *rubber duck debugging*. The idea is that if you clearly explain your situation to a rubber duck (or any inanimate object) and ask it a specific question, you’ll often be able to answer your own question. Some programming teams even keep a real rubber duck around to encourage people to “talk to the duck.”

Try It Again

Just going back to the start and trying again can be enough to solve many problems. Say you’re trying to write a for loop based on an example in this book. You might have only missed something simple, like a colon at the end of the for line. Going through the steps again might help you avoid repeating the same mistake.

Take a Break

If you’ve been working on the same problem for a while, taking a break is one of the best tactics you can try. When we work on the same task for long periods of time, our brains start to zero in on only one solution. We lose sight of the assumptions we’ve made, and taking a break helps us get a fresh perspective on the problem. It doesn’t need to be a long break, just something that gets you out of your current mindset. If you’ve been sitting for a long time, do something physical: take a short walk, go outside for a bit, or perhaps drink a glass of water or eat a light snack.

If you’re getting frustrated, it might be worth putting your work away for the day. A good night’s sleep almost always makes a problem more approachable.

Refer to This Book’s Resources

The online resources for this book, available at https://ehmatthes.github.io/pcc_3e, include a number of helpful sections about setting up your system and working through each chapter. If you haven’t done so already, take a look at these resources and see if there’s anything that helps your situation.